

Pinnacle PCTV MediaCenter came with the most feature rich remote, and was comfortable to handle.

The build quality of the AVerTV USB 2.0 was the most rugged, with its aluminium-like finish and compact, square form factor.

The Pinnacle MediaCenter was the most elegant looking of the three, with its cool blue LED and a nice curved shape.

When it came to bundled software, the Pinnacle PCTV provided the best PVR software, with all the necessary features. It also came bundled with Pinnacle MediaCenter.

The Tech-Com SSD-TV-811 came with a PVR known as the TV Jukebox, which supported MPEG-1/2/4 video capturing. The PVR software provided by AVerMedia supported MPEG-4 capture in addition to MPEG-1 and 2 capturing.



AverMedia AVerTV USB2.0

Performance

Not only did Pinnacle provide the best PVR application, the application also detected the most number of TV channels—73. The AVerTV and Tech-Com lagged behind with 67 and 66 channels respectively. Pinnacle also had the best image quality.

In the capture test, the Pinnacle dropped no frames, while AVerTV and Tech-Com dropped three and four frames respectively. Thus, once again, the Pinnacle MediaCenter emerged superior to the other two.

External Set-top Tuners

An external set-top TV tuner does not require a PC at all. All they need is a CRT monitor to display the video, while the inbuilt speaker delivers the audio. If you need better audio quality, connect the line out from the tuner to an amplified speaker system.

Tuners of this type display the best quality video on a CRT monitor as compared to the



Pinnacle PCTV USB2

previous two solutions, especially when the PC is off, because the RF interference from the PC is also shut off.

As you might have guessed, these TV tuners are only meant for TV viewing and cannot be used for capturing.

We received three tuners in this category, two from AVerMedia and one from Tech-Com.

Features

The AVerMedia TV tuners came with an easy-to-use remote. They also featured a function known as PIP (Picture-In-Picture), which displays TV video in a corner of your screen, while you use the rest of the desktop for your work. We tried to use this feature but failed. We even tried using different resolutions but it just did not work.

Both AVerMedia models looked very elegant with their silver finish and nicely placed buttons—which gave good tactile feedback. The difference between the two was that while the Box 5 supported a maximum resolution of 1024 x 768, the Box 9 model supported a maximum resolution of 1280 x 1024.

Internal PCI TV Tuners

External USB 2



External TV Tuners

External Set-Top Tuners



PixelView	PixelView	Tech-Com	AVerMedia	Pinnacle	Tech-Com	AVerMedia	AVerMedia	Tech-Com
MediaCentre PlayTV@P3000	PlayTV Pro 2	Super TV SSD-TV-670	AVerTV USB2.0	PCTV MediaCenter 100e	SSD-TV-811	AVerTV Box 5	AVerTV Box 9	SSD-TV-712
26.95	27.31	22.06	21.20	26.80	24.73	16.14	16.84	16.62
Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	External USB 2.0	External USB 2.0	External USB 2.0	Set-top Tuner	Set-top Tuner	Set-top Tuner
TV/FM	TV/FM	TV	TV	TV	TV	TV	TV	TV
Conexant Fusion 878A	Conexant Bt878	Philips SAA7130HL	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Stereo	Stereo	Mono	Mono	Mono	Mono	Mono	Mono	Mono
Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out, USB 2.0	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In, USB 2.0	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out, USB 2.0	Coaxial In, VGA In/Out, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, VGA In/Out, Audio In/Out	VGA In, VGA Out, S-Video In/Out, Audio In/Out, Coaxial In
✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
41	32	32	NA	41	22	37	37	25
FM aerial	Stereo cable, FM aerial	S-video to S-video, 3 to 1 AV cable, Stereo cable	USB cable, Stereo cable, Stereo to S-video cable	USB cable	USB cable, Stereo cable	VGA to TV box cable, Stereo cable, Power adapter	VGA to TV box cable, Stereo cable, Power adapter	VGA to TV box cable, Stereo cable, Power adapter
Drivers, PVR Software, InterVideo WinDVD	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software, Pinnacle MediaCenter	Drivers, PVR Software	NA	NA	NA
✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✗	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	NA	NA	NA
✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✓	NA	NA	NA
3.5	3.5	2.5	3	3.5	1	4	4	4
28.50	20.59	29.60	30.15	34.23	25.51	25.74	33.25	30.63
87	54	87	67	73	66	54	87	87
3.25	2.75	3.5	3.5	4	2.25	4.25	4.5	3.75
4	7	3	3	0	4	NA	NA	NA
16.19	26.98	20.25	3.85	3.86	9.00	5.40	4.91	20.25
2500	1500	1999	7000	6990	2999	7500	8250	1999
71.64	74.88	71.91	55.20	64.89	59.24	47.28	55.00	67.49